about the ambitious shipping line established by VOC. After confabulating with S.S.V. Vallinayagam Pillai, S.S.V. Easwaramurthia Pillai and other directors of the company, he said he was happy to inform the readers that all efforts had been made to resume the steamer service. Further, though over 3,000 shares had been subscribed in Colombo, many shares remained to be fully paid up. 'Galle-nesan' wondered if this may not be the case with Indian investors as well. 'What are the company's employees up to? Is it fair and just to draw salaries and eat and sleep?' he complained in exasperation. Somewhat worryingly, he also pointed out that BI had reversed the earlier rate cuts—a fact confirmed by a police report. This could only mean that BI believed it had killed competition and did not expect SSNCo to make a comeback.[55] 'It is hoped that at least now,' said 'Galle-nesan', 'the onion wholesale merchants and others will realize the worth of the Swadeshi company.'[56]

Responding to 'Galle-nesan', one 'Kandathuraippon' ('Plainspeaker'), said the former had written earlier as well, and wondered why the company's management was not keeping the public informed. He also helpfully suggested that they should seek the assistance of the National Fund.[57] One 'L.K.' mooted the idea of issuing donation tickets—an idea that, we shall see, was taken up in a few months.[58] Another proposed that a lottery be conducted for the benefit of the company.[59]

One A. Dorasami Mudaliar, a shareholder himself, responding to a letter in *The Hindu*, said that if only the company could have run the steamers for another fortnight some compromise could have been effected with the rival company—presumably on rates—and the company could have survived. 'It is no doubt a disgrace to discontinue at this stage, the effort has not been sufficiently tested as to be given up finally.'[60]

Lessons Learnt, a Little Too Late

In May 1909, a last-ditch effort was made to turn around the fortunes of the company when the government was once again declaring that 'the company is now on its last legs'[61]. On 7 June, some directors met informally and